

Q.7b (15 marks): Culture is unique to human beings - arguments in favour and against

Culture as per E.B. Taylor's book

"The primitive culture" is a complex whole of knowledge, art, morals, values, beliefs.

Culture exist nearly in every society, however whether it is unique to humans is debated.

Unique to humans

① Humans can modify the environment around them argued 'Herskovits', it is the man-made part of environment thus it should be unique to humans.

② It satisfies the need of individuals and society, which helps in maintaining social structure, social structure is part of human

Society not animals -

Animals do not have social structure but survival instincts dominate.

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③ Aristotle and Spencer talked of man as social animal → in order to survive → creates interdependence and thus society and culture forms. Such thing not happen in animals.

④ Culture is considered superorganic by Durkheim, Spencer and Kroeber. It has own set of rules and several institutions work to make it. It can thus be considered unique to humans. as it is shared collectively.

⑤ Kroeber said culture can't exist without society and such societies are product of human relations.

Not unique

① Jane Goodall study on Chimpanzee shows "terrible tool making" form of culture exist.

② Spain parliament in 2008 allowed for Human Rights for Great Apes as they remember dissections, learn from hearing symbols.

③ Some form of culture exist within animals (ex) Grooming in monkeys.

④ Unity and collaboration during feeding → observed among wild animals.

⑤ Language as form of culture is used → like making voice, swelling of genitals (for mating).

Thus, it can be said though some form of culture exist in other animals also, but complex forms of culture which we call superorganism and superindividuals is unique to humans.

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